Working-Town Social Deduction — Game Design Doc

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Elevator pitch

Six friends live and work in a small town for five days. Five are ordinary workers; one is secretly covering up a crime while holding down the same kind of job as everyone else.

Every job controls something the criminal needs, so the impostor has to lie, trade, steal and manipulate without looking suspicious. At the end of each day the town compares stories and evidence, but innocent players have secrets of their own. Catch the criminal before Day 5, or help them get away with it without realizing.

Core hook: one player runs a multi-step cover-up inside a functioning town, while everyone else does legitimate jobs that naturally overlap with the resources the impostor needs. Positioning: Among Us × Hitman-style sandbox × detective game, without combat.

Design pillars

These are the rules every system gets checked against. If a feature breaks one, cut or rework it.

1. **Every criminal action resembles at least one legitimate task.** If the impostor carries a suspicious bag, some jobs carry bags. If they need a tool, several jobs use it. If they need a restricted room, at least one civilian task sometimes sends people there.
2. **Evidence is never binary.** Aim for "I saw Zain leave the pharmacy carrying something," not "I saw red kill." Every suspicious act should have a plausible innocent explanation.
3. **Everyone has a real job, including the impostor.** The impostor is never the one person wandering aimlessly; their cover is built in.
4. **Innocents lie too.** Personal secrets give civilians reasons to act shifty, so lying is not proof of guilt.
5. **Work matters to the town.** Ignoring your shift to stalk suspects hurts the civilian team. The tension is "I think he's sus, but I still need to finish my shift."
6. **Small, dense, systemic.** Players should run into each other every couple of minutes. "Why are YOU here?" is the target moment, not "Where is everyone?"

7. **Crime is stylized.** Evidence bags, suspicious packages, contaminated clothes, stolen tools, forged records. Game-y and funny, not grim.

Round structure

Six players, five in-game days of 7–10 minutes each. Five are legitimate workers; one is secretly the criminal, randomly assigned a normal public job like everyone else. Civilians win by identifying the criminal; the criminal wins by completing the Day 5 cover-up or escape.



five-day round · crime objective and meeting power per day

Most deduction games loop task, meeting, task, meeting with no larger arc. Here each day escalates: crime objectives get riskier, records start appearing on Day 3, and meeting powers grow until the final accusation.

Task layers

Every player gets public job tasks plus a private personal task. The impostor gets both of those plus hidden crime tasks, and must juggle all three.

Layer	Who gets it	Visible to others?	Example (Mechanic)	Why it exists
Public job tasks	Everyone	Yes, completion shows in the day report	Repair two vehicles; pick up parts from the store; inspect the delivery van	Gives the impostor cover and feeds the town meter

Layer	Who gets it	Visible to others?	Example (Mechanic)	Why it exists
Personal secret	Everyone	No	Don't let anyone find out you damaged a customer's car	Makes innocents lie, creating organic false suspicion
Hidden crime tasks	Impostor only	No	Obtain a restricted item; move evidence; alter a record	The impostor's win condition

Example personal secrets

- Shopkeeper: make $500 today.
- Mechanic: hide that you damaged a customer's car.
- Doctor: you misplaced medication; recover it quietly.
- Delivery driver: finish every delivery before closing.

The impostor's tradeoff: do the job well and look innocent, or spend time on the crime and fall behind on work. Poor work performance shows up at meetings as circumstantial evidence, never proof.

Crossover rule: innocent tasks must routinely send players to the back alley, pharmacy storage, warehouse and garbage area. If only the impostor ever goes there, players solve the meta in three rounds.

Jobs

Each profession is both a job and an information source. Avoid "press E three times to mop the floor"; every job should carry a social responsibility.

Job	Controls	Can investigate	Legit behaviour that looks suspicious
Shopkeeper	Stock; who gets items	Purchase records; notices missing stock	Handing out restricted items on request
Construction worker	Warehouse access; tool lending	Yard cameras	Opening restricted storage

Job	Controls	Can investigate	Legit behaviour that looks suspicious
Mechanic	Garages; vehicle repairs	Which vehicles were used, and when	Moving vehicles nobody ordered
Doctor / pharmacist	Medical supplies	Injuries, status effects, contamination; medical records	Frequent pharmacy storage visits
Sanitation worker	Rubbish removal around town	Inspect discarded objects	Carrying bags; may destroy evidence by accident
Delivery driver	Packages between locations	Who ordered what	Constantly carrying boxes between buildings

The impostor is assigned one of these jobs at random; there is no visible impostor role.

Evidence and records

The town generates paper trails: clues, never proof. Players bring them to the nightly meeting, and voice chat does the rest.

Record	Source	Example
Store receipt	Shopkeeper	Industrial gloves purchased at 14:32
Warehouse log	Construction	Storage Room B opened at 16:10
Delivery log	Delivery driver	Package delivered to Garage
CCTV	Cameras at fixed spots	Person in yellow jacket entered alley
Vehicle log	Mechanic	Van used 18:00–18:15
Witness statement	Any player	"I saw him leave the pharmacy carrying something"

Records should be partial: a time without a name, a jacket colour without a face, an item without a buyer. The impostor can also target records (alter a log, forge a receipt) as a crime task.

Town stability and the day report

Every completed job task feeds a shared Town Stability meter (or Revenue / Reputation). If it collapses, civilians lose even if they caught the criminal. This stops the game degenerating into six people stalking each other from Day 1.

At the end of each day, before the meeting, everyone sees a report like this:

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DAY 2 REPORT
Town productivity: 82%

Mechanic       3/4 tasks
Shopkeeper     4/4
Sanitation     2/3
Doctor         4/4
Delivery       3/5
Construction   4/4

Suspicious events:
- Warehouse inventory discrepancy
- Unregistered vehicle movement
- Missing cleaning supplies
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The report gives the group concrete things to argue about instead of pure vibes. A low task count is a lead, not a verdict: the delivery driver may just have had five tasks.

Meetings and accusations

No daily ejection vote. With six players, Among Us-style voting collapses the round: one random Day 1 vote and one wrong Day 2 vote leave four players. Instead, meeting powers escalate.

Night	Meeting power
1	Discuss only
2	Place one player under surveillance

Night	Meeting power
3	Issue a search warrant
4	Arrest vote
5	Final accusation

Alternative to test: the town holds a single arrest warrant for the whole game. Either way, a wrong accusation should hand the impostor a major advantage so nobody spams votes.

Impostor freedom and replayability

Each crime phase has several routes, so players can't memorize "construction yard = impostor." A fixed list (go store, take knife, go warehouse) is solved after ten games.

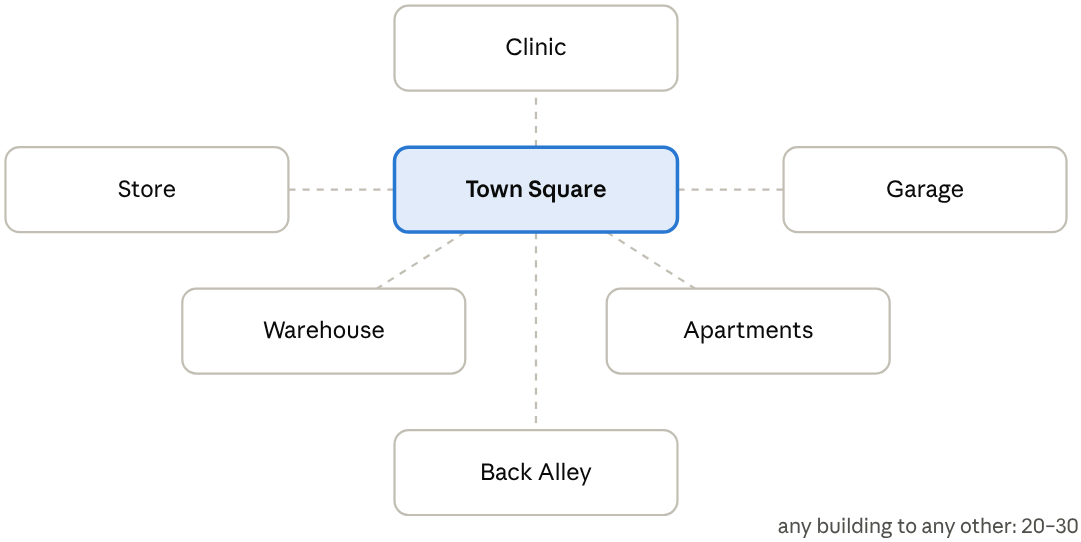
Crime phase	Route A	Route B	Route C
Acquire tool	Buy or beg from the shop	Borrow from the warehouse	Lift from the garage
Obtain restricted material	Pharmacy storage	Warehouse Room B	Intercept a delivery
Move evidence	Delivery package	Sanitation bag	Vehicle trunk
Create alibi	Forge a record	Get seen doing a job task	Ask someone to vouch
Dispose / escape	Sanitation route	Construction route	Transport route

Each route forces interaction with a different player's workplace. One round the criminal keeps visiting sanitation; the next they never leave the mechanic's side.

Map

No city. The demo is one tiny town block of about seven locations, dense enough that players bump into each other constantly.

Every building is one short walk from the town square



any building to any other: 20–30 s on foot

demo town block · 7 locations

The Town Square is the hub every route crosses, which maximizes chance sightings. The Back Alley, Warehouse storage and garbage area must also appear in civilian tasks so visiting them isn't a tell.

MVP scope

The first playable answers one question: do friends naturally start lying to each other? If yes, expand.

Build

- [ ] 4 players: 3 civilians, 1 impostor
- [ ] 3 jobs: Shopkeeper, Mechanic, Sanitation
- [ ] 3-day round, 7–10 minutes per day
- [ ] One tiny street
- [ ] Public job tasks + one personal secret each
- [ ] 3 hidden impostor objectives, at least 2 routes each
- [ ] Basic inventory
- [ ] Simple records (receipts, one camera, one log)
- [ ] Town stability meter + end-of-day report
- [ ] Night meeting with proximity voice

- [ ] One accusation at the end

Don't build yet: skill trees, cosmetics, NPC traffic, thirty jobs, procedural cities, combat, a GTA-scale map.

Open questions to playtest

- [ ] Escalating meeting powers, or one arrest warrant for the whole game?
- [ ] What exactly does a wrong accusation give the impostor?
- [ ] How low can Town Stability fall before civilians lose, and is that fun or frustrating?
- [ ] Does the impostor win on completing all crime tasks, or only on surviving Day 5?
- [ ] Are 7–10 minute days too long for 4 players on one street?
- [ ] Do personal secrets create enough false suspicion without drowning the real signal?
- [ ] Should players be able to lock resources or deny requests, and how does that affect the Day 4 panic?